



Interpersonal Conflict in Children's Animated Films. A Comparative Study of Classic and Postmodern Cinema

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1. Summary

Animated films have a strong influence on children's socialization processes. The shift in thinking brought about by the postmodern perspective has altered the way stories are told, which in turn affects socialization processes. Analyzing the psychosocial factors present in animated films is of great importance, as children acquire behaviors through this medium. The objective of this analysis is to describe how interpersonal conflicts are portrayed and to compare this portrayal in classic cinema (up to 1968) and postmodern cinema (from 1990 onward). Interpersonal conflict is a complex phenomenon of great importance in cinema, as it is the core and driving force of subplots and character relationships. The reference points for the analysis of conflicts were the hierarchical structure and the power imbalance between characters, as well as the use of violence to resolve conflicts and the representation of gender roles. These elements shape how characters of both genders manage conflicts. A cinematic content analysis was conducted on a sample of films, focusing on the behavior of the protagonists and their developed subplots.

The results reveal a significant shift in the portrayal of interpersonal conflicts from one era to another. In classic cinema, the source of conflicts stems from the differing roles characteristic of Parsonian functionalism, whereas in contemporary cinema, conflicts arise when the assigned role is called into question. Hierarchical structure is a highly significant element in animated cinema, and it shapes the conflict strategies of the characters involved. While in classic cinema the hierarchy remains unchanged, in contemporary cinema it undergoes a shift due to the protagonist's actions. Furthermore, the portrayal of women's roles has changed drastically from one era of cinema to another. In classical cinema, women could be the catalyst for conflict but played a completely passive role in its resolution, whereas in contemporary cinema they have gradually gained autonomy, to the point of managing conflicts in a manner similar to male protagonists. The use of violence in conflict resolution has hardly changed from one period to another. In both eras, violence is key to the development of relationships between characters and the resolution of conflict. However, in postmodern cinema, there are instances that attempt to condemn violence, though they continue to resort to it, as its comic element makes it highly appealing to the viewer. Finally, in postmodern cinema, the journey appears, used as a narrative device to develop conflicts. The journey facilitates encounters, as well as obstacles that must be overcome cooperatively and that ultimately transform the relationships between characters.

The shift in how conflicts are portrayed in animated films is a direct result of a change in the mindset of their creators. In the classical era, film served an indoctrinating function aimed at fostering conformity, whereas contemporary film seems to empower young people to defend their individuality. Similarly, the shift in the representation of gender roles will presumably have a positive impact on young people's expectations regarding conflict, as they will view both genders as equally capable. Violence is a controversial element in animation, as there is no consensus on its potential influence on children's behavior and, therefore, on its use as a conflict resolution strategy.

Keywords

interpersonal conflict; cinema; animation; violence; gender stereotypes

2. Introduction

Film is an art form that serves as a cultural mirror of the society in which it exists. However, film in general—and children's animation in particular—also functions as an industry whose goal is to entertain the masses. Thus, to be successful, the industry must reflect, or at least align with, the prevailing mindset in order to reach as many viewers as possible. As for children, cinema must represent the values of parents, who typically decide what content to show their children. Children spend a large portion of their leisure time watching cartoons, whether in series or feature-length films. Children and adolescents aged 8 to 18 watch television, on average, four and a half hours a day (Rideout et al., 2010). Audiovisual media play a significant role in children's socialization process (Signorielli, 1990), leading them to imitate and adopt behaviors observed in these media as their own (American Academy of Pediatrics, 2001).

According to Bandura's social learning theory (1969, 1976), audiovisual media provide behavioral models whose actions are subject to a series of contingencies. Through observation, viewers learn and replicate these behaviors in similar situations. Through the media, children acquire knowledge about the world around them and learn how to solve problems (Fisch, 2004; Van Evra, 2004), such as everyday interpersonal conflicts. Cultivation theory (Gerbner, 1998) posits that the media influence beliefs about the world and, consequently, behavior. For example, viewing violent content would lead one to believe that resolving conflicts aggressively is effective and would not have negative consequences (Hofferth, 2010).

These media, which include animated films, reflect the dominant values of the era, making it possible to trace their evolution by comparing works from one period to another. Until the mid-20th century, the perspective of modernity dominated society, with Parsons' functionalism (1951/1999) being one of its most representative theories. According to this author, people act by fulfilling roles determined by the norms and values of the society in which they live. The maintenance of these roles enables the functioning and reproduction of social institutions and structures, such as the traditional family structure. The prevailing system is maintained and reproduced through socialization and social control. In this way, animated films represent the functionality of these roles through their characters, influencing children's socialization process and seeking to perpetuate the social structure. For example, depicting submissive female characters who handle household chores allows girls to learn that their role in society is to live in a subordinate position to their husbands and to domestic tasks.

In the 1960s, a great deal of criticism began to emerge regarding this functionalist view of modernity. Certain social movements, such as Marxism and feminism, criticized Parsonsian functionalism for allowing the reproduction of existing major inequalities, and emphasized the importance of conflict and social change (Holmwood, 2005), thereby challenging the roles proposed by this theory. In response to the rejection of this view of modernity, a large number of social theories emerged, which can be grouped under the paradigm of postmodernity. The postmodern vision rejects the dogma and the pursuit of objective knowledge characteristic of modernity, emphasizing the importance of multiple perspectives (Gergen, 1991/2006). Thus, the logic of this paradigm is the rejection of the search for consensus in all fields of knowledge, from the arts to the sciences and politics. Two historical milestones that disrupted the dynamics of

The shift from a clash of opposing perspectives vying for the truth (the logic of modernity) to an emphasis on the diversity of perspectives (characteristic of postmodernity) was epitomized by the student uprisings of May 1968 in France and the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989.

Cinema, as an emerging cultural and artistic medium in the 20th century, was not immune to this paradigm shift. The logic of postmodernity affected this medium primarily in two ways. First, these feature films challenge classical narrative structures and advocate for the inclusion of new and avant-garde narrative and cinematic elements (Kretzschmar, 2002). One example is the breaking of the “fourth wall” so that characters can address the audience. Second, cinema reflects the sociopolitical reality of the moment; thus, under this social paradigm, it seeks to reject the representation of dogmas and promotes subjectivity in storytelling (Molina Foix, 1995). In children’s animated films, Disney’s dogmatism is challenged thanks to the emergence of new studios (e.g., DreamWorks), which bring a greater diversity of stories to the big screen—stories that break away from the rigid framework of classic animated cinema. Examples of this include the introduction of antihero protagonists and the emergence of female heroes.

Film narratives reflect a wide range of psychosocial phenomena by depicting the adventures of characters who interact with one another. Interpersonal conflict plays a significant role in these stories, as it serves as the driving force behind the subplots (Sánchez-Escalonilla, 2004). However, this phenomenon has not been sufficiently analyzed from a social perspective, as research aimed at studying conflict has focused on social or intercultural conflict (e.g., Pérez Romero and González-Fierro Santos, 2011; Rigoletto, 2014; Ruiz Castillo and Escribano Gutiérrez, 2007; Smets, 2015), with the exception of the seminar compilation by De la Torre (1999).

2.1. Cultural tradition, plot premises, and screenplays

2.1.1. Cultural tradition and plot premises

To understand the conflicts in cinematic narratives, it is essential to understand their origin and the central thread that drives the story, since these conflicts are constructed through narrative and cinematic elements and serve as the driving force of the film. Disney stories, especially the classics, have simple, linear plots with clearly defined concepts of good and evil. One of the main reasons is that they were easier to adapt into animated feature films (Davis, 2006). Thus, fairy tales—and, to a lesser extent, myths from European culture, such as the stories of the Brothers Grimm or the myth of Hercules—were adapted and simplified. These stories from ancient and medieval times served a didactic function, aiming to teach a moral lesson that would help educate children (in the case of fairy tales) by showing them inappropriate behaviors that should be punished.

Contemporary films introduce original stories (e.g., *Coco*) or modify old stories to such an extent that they are practically unrecognizable (e.g., *Moana*). The emergence of postmodern logic has led to a rejection of conveying classical morals, promoting messages of a different nature. Thus, it is possible that the approach to these stories has changed drastically. As for the characters’ conflicts, this shift would translate into a change in the underlying motives that justify the conflicts.

Campbell (1949/1959) conducted an in-depth anthropological analysis of these mythical stories that influenced all subsequent studies. In the film industry, Vogler (1985), who worked as a screenplay consultant at Disney, wrote a brief monograph introducing this perspective on myths to the majority of Hollywood directors and screenwriters. Campbell

established the monomyth, which refers to the formula common to all mythological stories in any culture, including fairy tales. The monomyth begins with a hero who receives the *call to adventure*, which may be an accidental event that reveals a world previously unknown to the protagonist. The adventure consists of the hero's journey to an unknown realm that can take many forms (e.g., an island, a forest, or the underworld). There is a variation on the call to adventure: the *refusal of the call*, which leads to a negative adventure, where the hero becomes a victim who must be rescued.

According to Campbell's model, the first encounter in the adventure is with a *protective figure*, who endows the adventurer with supernatural powers that will enable him to complete his journey. Just before reaching the unknown land, the hero must overcome the *guardian of the threshold*, who guards the entrance and symbolizes the effort of moving from the known to the unknown. However, crossing the threshold usually involves a defeat, and the hero is swallowed up by the unknown. Once this threshold is crossed, the hero must face a *series of trials* that he can overcome thanks to the supernatural aid he has already received. At the end of the journey lies the trophy, which the hero must obtain to *return home* and bring it back to the realm of humanity, from whence he came. Thanks to further supernatural aid, the hero can return, but often must be rescued by the outside world after crossing the threshold again. At that moment, the hero will be recognized by society and will hold power over both worlds. The transitions from one phase to another of the journey serve as the axes of the mythological hero's intrapersonal conflict, whose intrapsychic complexity is simplified in cinema, creating enemies that externalize the hero's internal struggle (Balló and Pérez, 1995/2005). In this way, a necessary interpersonal conflict between characters is created in virtually all films inspired by mythology.

There is a significant difference between the hero of myth and the hero of the fairy tale. The former is a character with extraordinary qualities (e.g., *Hercules*), while the latter is typically a young or otherwise marginalized child (e.g., *Pinocchio*) who acquires magical powers to overcome his oppressors (Campbell, 1949/1959). Thus, the fairy tale hero achieves domestic and microscopic triumphs, while the mythic hero achieves a macroscopic, historical triumph that enables the regeneration of society. The protagonists of animated films, which are more inspired by fairy tales, typically face interpersonal conflicts that have no impact on society, more closely resembling the everyday conflicts of the average viewer.

From a cinematic perspective, animated film adaptations of myths and fairy tales mostly take the form of adventure films. According to Balló and Pérez (1995/2005), "what cinema does is evoke earlier narrative models through a staging that makes a particular story seem new, fresh, and newly invented, suggesting a contemporary way of understanding a plot that has already been told" (p. 11). Thus, for these authors, the plot of adventure films has as its prototype the myth of Jason and the Argonauts, in which Jason must embark on a dangerous journey to obtain the Golden Fleece. Upon completing the journey, he must face Aeetes by overcoming a series of trials, which he manages to accomplish thanks to the help of Medea, Aeetes's daughter. Upon obtaining the Golden Fleece, he sets out to return to his homeland, Iolcus, with Medea, but is pursued by Aeetes. In the end, they arrive safely in Iolcus with the Golden Fleece. From this legend are drawn the key elements of the fundamental plot of adventure cinema: a *quest*, a *long and dangerous journey*, a *confrontation* at the destination, *unexpected help*, a *perilous escape*, and a *victorious return* (Balló and Pérez, 1995/2005). However, adventure feature films usually end with the acquisition of the "Golden Fleece," omitting the supposed return.

2.1.2. Interpersonal Conflict in Screenplays

A film can be constructed and analyzed based on the disruption of equilibrium that occurs when the protagonist sets a difficult goal for himself (Sánchez-Escalonilla, 2004). The disruption must be strong enough to provoke a dramatic conflict, which is the true source of the problems. From the dramatic conflict, four phases of the action can be distinguished, according to Vale (1986/1996). First is the *unaltered stage*, which refers to the initial situation, where the characters and circumstances are introduced. Next comes the *alteration*; something appears that disrupts the initial balance, and the motive that drives someone to resolve the conflict emerges. The first two phases correspond to the story's *exposition*. Third comes the *struggle*, which refers to the action itself (the *climax*). It involves not only the protagonists but also the other characters who support or hinder the objective. The struggle is the development of the conflict, and without it, the story's development would not be possible. Finally, there is the *resolution (denouement)*, where the action concludes once the plot's objective has been fulfilled. This phase does not involve a return to the starting point, since progress has been made that prevents the situation from ending the same way it began.

Although the central idea of the adventure story serves as the framework that gives the narrative its meaning, it is not the primary source for conveying the values and lessons that enable us to understand and address conflicts. Tobias (1993/1999) argues that these overarching plots are necessary elements, but they reduce the script to a single overarching story. Within a film, several narratives coexist, including at least the story of the protagonist's goal (main plot), the stories of the relationships between the characters (subplots), and the story that traces the protagonists' evolution (transformation arc) (Sánchez-Escalonilla, 2004). It is within the subplots that conflicts are constructed, and for some, this is the central aspect of the film (Seeger, 1991). A plot may contain as many subplots as there are relationships between characters, but it must focus on one or two—the developed subplots (Sánchez-Escalonilla, 2004)—which narrate the story's most important conflicts in depth.

Animated films are works of fiction, so it is important that the screenplay succeeds in lending them realistic nuances. To achieve this, characters must be designed who, despite being clearly fictional and impossible, become part of the experience, allowing the viewer to empathize with their struggles (Sánchez-Escalonilla, 2004). Characters must be designed to possess humanity, since if there are flaws in the presentation of conflicts, the ethical and psychological reality of the characters can become distorted and difficult for the viewer to recognize. The characters' behavior must be believable and consistent with their psychological reality. The conflict in the subplots is not limited to events in the plot but leaves a mark on the personalities and behaviors of the characters involved, enabling their arc of transformation (Sánchez-Escalonilla, 2004). In this way, screenwriters strive to create believable stories and characters that, despite the inherent differences of fiction, allow the viewer to identify with them. They strive to construct realistic conflicts that can be extrapolated to everyday life.

2.2. Foundations of Interpersonal Conflict in Animated Film

2.2.1. Theories of conflict

The way conflicts are addressed in animated films may change over time, reflecting the prevailing ideas and values that screenwriters and directors wish to convey. These changes may influence the aforementioned socialization processes in different ways. Hocker and Wilmot (2018) define interpersonal conflict as an overt confrontation between at least two interdependent parties who perceive incompatible goals, scarce resources, and interference from the other party in

achieve those goals. This definition excludes latent or non-manifest conflicts, which are abundant in everyday life and have a significant impact on interpersonal relationships. However, these authors' definition aligns with the specific context of animated films, which are generally aimed at a child audience. To make the story easier for young viewers to understand, screenwriters often make all possible components explicit, simplifying the film's narrative structure. Consequently, latent conflicts are generally not included in narratives of this genre, as they would likely hinder comprehension. There are various typologies that organize the causes of conflict, such as those proposed by Deutsch (1973) or Redorta (2018). These typologies are highly useful in fields such as mediation, but conflicts in film are constructed based on plot-driven criteria, so they may not be as useful for film analysis.

Movies sometimes depict a specific story that aims to reflect the social reality of the groups to which the characters belong. As a result, these narratives may feature intergroup phenomena that are interpreted in an interpersonal context, since the characters represent a particular group. Regarding conflict management, two theories are particularly relevant, as they describe ways to successfully resolve intergroup conflicts: superordinate goals and Intergroup Contact Theory. Superordinate goals were described by Sherif (1958, 1966) in the context of Realistic Conflict Theory (Sherif et al., 1961; Sherif & Sherif, 1953). This theory posits that intergroup hostility is directly related to competition for scarce and valuable resources. Superordinate goals refer to objectives shared by the conflicting groups that can only be achieved through collaboration. Thus, it is impossible for one group to achieve the objective independently or to achieve it at the expense of the other group. The cooperation required to achieve the objective makes competition unfeasible, thereby reducing tensions between the groups involved.

On the other hand, the Intergroup Contact Theory was proposed by Allport (1954) and has been the subject of numerous studies and critiques. This author posits that, under certain conditions, mere contact between conflicting groups can reduce intergroup hostility. For an optimal contact situation to occur, the following conditions must be met: equality of status; pursuit of common goals; intergroup cooperation; and institutional support. Due to the extensive criticism the original model received, Pettigrew (1998) reformulated the IGT by drawing on various empirical studies and integrating the explanatory hypotheses of this theory. In this way, he developed a three-phase model based on the decategorization model (Brewer and Miller, 1984), the common ingroup identity model (Gaertner et al., 1996), and the mutual distinctiveness model (Hewstone and Brown, 1986). The first phase corresponds to the decategorization model, which proposes that contact between members of different groups allows one to appreciate the other person's personal characteristics, making information about the reference group less salient. This process allows members of the other group to be perceived individually. The second phase, if the first has been successful, corresponds to the mutual distinctiveness model, which proposes that contact situations allow for the maintenance of positive distinctiveness in the important dimensions of identity, while favoring the other group when comparing dimensions of lesser relevance. The final phase corresponds to the common ingroup identity model, which proposes that contact allows for the creation of a supergroup identity that encompasses both groups, thereby enabling the sharing of a reference group.

To analyze how characters respond to conflict, one can refer to the two-dimensional model proposed by Rahim and Bonoma (1979). The model proposed by these authors, which has since become a classic, distinguishes two dimensions: interest

self-interest and concern for others. The combination of these dimensions allows us to distinguish five groups of strategies. First, *domination* is characterized by the desire to achieve one's own goal without regard for the other party. It has a win-lose orientation, as it aims to outdo the other party in resolving the conflict. The second strategy is *submission* or *servility*, which is characterized by yielding to the other party and giving up one's own goal. This corresponds to a lose-win orientation, as it aims for the other party to achieve their goal at the expense of one's own. The third style is *avoidance* or *inaction*, where the person tries to distance themselves from the conflict and confrontation, delaying it but never resolving it. The fourth strategy is *integration*, *problem-solving*, or *cooperation*, which aims for both parties to fully achieve their goals. It is a win-win orientation, as it seeks the total satisfaction of both parties. Finally, the *tendency toward compromise* is the strategy that aims for both parties to partially achieve their objectives at the cost of making more or fewer concessions, so that both parties are satisfied even if they do not achieve their initial goals. There is one final type of orientation, lose-lose, which arises when one party is aware of the impossibility of achieving its goal and tries to sabotage the other party so that it cannot achieve its goal either. The various strategies can be implemented proactively or reactively. The first approach involves using strategies on one's own initiative, while the second involves using them in response to the other party's actions. For example, in movies, it is common for the villain to attack the hero (proactive) and for the hero to respond by fighting back or fleeing (reactive).

Hierarchical relationships have a significant influence on the emergence of conflicts (Greer et al., 2018), as well as on the behavior of the parties involved (Anicich et al., 2015; Rahim, 1986). Magee and Galinsky (2008) distinguish between status and power as the foundations of hierarchical structure. For these authors, status refers to respect and admiration from others, while power is the asymmetric control over valuable resources. Power is a fundamental concept for understanding interpersonal conflict, as it shapes the behaviors of the parties in conflict (Hocker and Wilmot, 2018). Authors such as Weber (1922/1993) or Raven and French (1959) developed typologies of power, which have become classic models in the study of conflict. Weber distinguished three types of authority or power: charismatic, traditional, and legal-rational. First, *charismatic authority* refers to the power a person acquires through their ability to charm others, becoming an extraordinary figure in the eyes of others (e.g., a cult leader). Second, *traditional authority* refers to power that is legitimized through belief in established traditions within society (e.g., a monarch). Third and finally, *legal-rational authority* is that which is legitimized through a legal body, which is theoretically created in a rational manner by a specific society.

On the other hand, Raven and French (1959) identified five types of power. The first type, *coercive power*, is exercised by forcing the other person to obey. *Reward power* is the power that promises to reward the other party with something they value. *Legitimate power* is power that derives its legitimacy from established norms that are not questioned. *Expert power* is possessed by individuals with extensive knowledge and skill in a specific subject. The final type, *referent power*, is found in individuals who are admired and respected by the other party. Both typologies can be useful for film analysis, and when combined, they expand and refine Magee and Galinsky's dichotomy regarding the foundations of hierarchy. In the business context, Anicich et al. (2015) note that individuals with high power but low status are the most likely to generate interpersonal conflicts by exercising coercive power. In animated films based on fairy tales, as described above, the protagonists are often initially oppressed by the antagonist, who typically exercises coercive power.

There are other elements of great importance in the development of conflicts that have been extensively studied in animation and that can serve as points of reference in the analysis: the representation of gender roles and the use of violence. Hierarchy is another aspect that, although less analyzed, also deserves special attention due to its widespread presence in animated films.

2.2.2. Hierarchy and Power

Dorfman and Mattelart (1987) conducted an in-depth analysis of the Donald Duck (Disney) comic strips, which can be considered the precursors to animated films. For these authors, these seemingly childish stories are nothing more than projections by adults of an idealized, golden childhood, serving to distance themselves from daily conflicts through a magical world. Adult values are projected onto children, passing from one generation to the next. There is a highly vertical and authoritarian relationship among the characters. Those with less power must be obedient, submissive, and disciplined, while the most powerful exert constant coercion through threats and repression. It is a strongly hierarchical and cruel world, but it must not be shown as such, since the moment inequality becomes apparent, rebellion is necessary. Thus, the characters assume the role assigned to them and do not question the consequences of their position relative to others. The only horizontal relationship in these stories is that between characters of equal standing, but they are forced to compete to see who outdoes the other. Artz (2003) argues that in Disney films, hierarchy is a prerequisite. In each film, there appears to be a variation in the hierarchical system (e.g., colonialism in *Pocahontas* or royalty and castes in *Aladdin*), but the strongly vertical structure remains the same. According to this author, power remains unchanged and is justified by the positive characteristics of the protagonists, whom he refers to as “the elite,” in contrast to the villains.

2.2.3. Gender Roles

Starting in the 1970s, thanks to the momentum of the feminist movement, the portrayal of women in children’s animation of the time—as well as in other television content—was called into question. Children tend to imitate characters of their own gender more than those of the opposite gender (Courtney and Whipple, 1983). Specifically, the media plays an important role in shaping behaviors typical of gender roles (Remafedi, 1990). Thus, a sexist portrayal of characters and how they handle conflicts will create biased expectations among young viewers regarding conflict management, leading them to view, for example, men as more capable of resolving their conflicts independently.

Until the 1990s, various analyses of cartoons agreed that women were underrepresented, and when they did appear, their roles were clearly stereotypical. Women in animation were less active, needed to be rescued, devoted themselves to housework, were prone to falling in love, and, when they demonstrated any ability, were belittled or ridiculed (e.g., Barcus, 1983; Courtney and Whipple, 1983; Levinson, 1975; Mayes and Valentine, 1979; Sternglanz and Serbin, 1974; Streicher, 1974). Dorfman and Mattelart (1987) summarized women’s behavior as follows:

[The woman] perfectly fulfills her role as a humble servant (subordinate to the man) and as a beauty queen who is always courted (subordinate to the suitor). The only power she is allowed is traditional seduction, which takes the form of flirtation. She cannot go any further, because then she would abandon her domestic and passive role. (p.35)

In the 1980s, the portrayal of women in animation began to become less stereotypical (Durkin, 1985; Thompson and Zerbinos, 1995; Vande Berg and Streckfuss, 1992). Women began to be portrayed as more independent, assertive, intelligent, and competent than in more traditional animation. Furthermore, they began to play more prominent roles in the stories, with female leadership emerging (Thompson and Zerbinos, 1995). Animation from this period represents a transitional phase between classic animation—which embodies the ideals of the Victorian patriarchal family—and contemporary animation, which seeks to incorporate a postmodern perspective that is increasingly feminist (Davis, 2006).

Studies from the past decade are divided between those that deny any change in the portrayal of female characters (Ahmed and Wahab, 2014; Aley and Hahn, 2020; Michael et al., 2012; Sharmin and Sattar, 2018) and those that suggest the evolution is positive and in line with shifts in popular thought, although total equality does not exist (England et al., 2011; Gökçearslan, 2010; Radovic and Radulovic, 2016; Tsotsou and Stamou, 2018). The most radical perspectives are those that argue there has been virtually no change in the representation of traditional gender roles. For Ahmed and Wahab (2014), television promotes the dominant ideology, specifically patriarchy. The media, and specifically animation, promote male domination over women, “training” boys to be more active, intelligent, and aggressive, while girls are encouraged to be attractive and passive. Cartoons associate men with a positive stereotype and women with a negative one (Ahmed and Wahab, 2014). Sharmin and Sattar (2018) highlight that, beyond the portrayal of female protagonists, the portrayal of female villains is negative for young viewers. The motivations that lead women to become villains, compared to those of male villains, merely reinforce the symbols of male patriarchy. Similarly, movie *posters* reinforce typical gender role stereotypes, highlighting men more than women, portraying them as strong and brave while women are weak (Aley and Hahn, 2020).

On the other hand, England et al. (2011) note that gender stereotypes remain present in Disney princesses, although the portrayal of these characters has become more complex over the years, reflecting changes in gender roles in American society. Similarly, princes have also become more complex, with some being portrayed as incompetent and less than noble (e.g., *The Princess and the Frog*). The increasingly complex portrayal of gender roles responds to the expectations of Western society, which, following the inclusion of women in traditionally male-dominated fields, have become more complex (Radovic and Radulovic, 2016). Female characters in contemporary children’s animated films have undergone an “update,” as they do not reject the classic image of the sweet and kind woman but have incorporated behaviors that were typically masculine, such as independence (Tsotsou and Stamou, 2018). The portrayal of princesses has become more complex, as new, emancipated protagonists coexist with others who have undergone a “re-traditionalization” (activities, clothing, desires). This may be because there is no longer a single image of the ideal woman; rather, various discourses coexist without a dominant meta-narrative (Radovic and Radulovic, 2016).

Experimental studies investigating the influence of gender roles depicted in animation on children are relatively scarce. The most classic studies indicate that greater exposure to television positively correlates with more traditional ideas about gender roles (Frueh and McGhee, 1975; Williams, 1981), with children being aware of the different gender roles depicted in cartoons (Mayes and Valentine, 1979). Regarding preferences for certain characters, boys prefer stereotypical content, being drawn to male characters, while girls prefer female characters only when they view content that is

stereotypical or gender-neutral (Aubrey and Harrison, 2004). Stereotypical portrayals of genders and their behavior in animation can create unrealistic expectations about how each gender should handle conflicts. Girls may internalize the idea that their ability to manage and resolve conflicts is inferior to that of boys, as they are expected to be passive. On the other hand, boys may underestimate women's autonomy in this regard. Empirically, differences between men and women in conflict management are very small and become increasingly smaller as they age (Hocker and Wilmot, 2018).

2.2.4. Use of violence

Along with the portrayal of gender roles, the use of violence has been one of the most extensively studied aspects of animation. Violence is frequently used to resolve conflicts quickly (Fry and Fry, 2013; Johnson and Johnson, 1995), although its use is currently condemned by society. Starting in the 1950s, the belief—still prevalent today—began to spread that violence shown on television, and specifically in cartoons, had a negative effect on children's behavior, as they replicated the aggressive actions they saw on screen. Consequently, a large body of empirical research began to emerge, studying the influence of this type of content on children's behavior (e.g., Bandura, 1968; Bandura et al., 1963; Mussen and Rutherford, 1961; Siegel, 1956). In Hapkiewicz's now-classic review (1979), the various studies conducted up to that point were compared, and the findings were found to be inconclusive. The great heterogeneity of samples, dependent variables, and methods of measurement means that results are inconsistent from one study to another. However, the author suggests three aspects to consider: the content of the animation, the similarity between the character and the viewer, and the child's ability to distinguish between reality and fiction, which is closely related to age.

The most recent reviews suggest that the influence of violence in cartoons is likely very low (Blumberg et al., 2008; Kirsh, 2006; Peters & Blumberg, 2002). One of the hypotheses underpinning these studies is the idea formulated by Mueller and Donnerstein (1983), which suggests that violence depicted in cartoons increases aggressive *arousal*, albeit only momentarily. Thus, the aggression observed in studies where measurements are taken immediately after viewing the violence (e.g., Bandura et al., 1963; Mussen and Rutherford, 1961) would not persist over time and would not influence behavior when facing conflicts. On the other hand, Kirsh (2006), like Hapkiewicz, highlights perceived realism as a possible determining factor in the influence of audiovisual media violence. This realism would stem from perceived similarity and relevance. Perceived similarity refers to the resemblance the viewer perceives between their own life and what is seen on television. Higher levels of similarity would allow for greater identification with the characters, which would increase perceived realism (Potter, 2003). On the other hand, perceived reality refers to the possibility that the events shown on television could actually happen. If the viewer perceives that the violent act could happen in their environment, they will be more likely to replicate it (Bandura, 1965). For example, if a child watches a cartoon where one character steals a pencil from another at school (high perceived reality) and the other character attacks them to get it back, the young viewer may learn that violence is an effective strategy for resolving conflicts at school. However, the effect is presumably greater if the characters are human (high perceived realism) rather than animals (low perceived realism).

Various studies suggest that children, from an early age, are able to distinguish between reality and fiction (Blumberg et al., 2008; Kirsh, 2006; Peters and Blumberg, 2002). This allows young people, when watching animated characters, to perceive them

as less realistic, which presumably reduces the impact of violence on their behavior, making it less likely for them to imitate violent behaviors as a means of resolving conflicts. Furthermore, Kirsh (2006) argues that comedy animation—which includes the vast majority of the most popular feature films—allows for the trivialization of the violence depicted therein, even though children perceive higher levels of violence in this genre (Haynes, 1978). One of the key factors enabling the trivialization of comic violence is the legitimization of violent acts, which depends on their consequences (Potter and Warren, 1998). When the aggressor is rewarded for the violent act, or goes unpunished, the aggression is perceived as more morally acceptable. Fernández Villanueva et al. (2006) add that, beyond the consequences, the portrayal of characters is a key factor influencing the acceptance or rejection of violence. Thus, if the aggressor character is portrayed as a hero who uses violence to solve problems, the aggression will be more easily legitimized. Similarly, this effect is reinforced if the victim of the aggression is portrayed as evil or deserving of punishment.

In any case, humor—specifically comic violence—is one of the keys to the success of children’s animation, since children find violence very amusing (Sinnott and Ross, 1976); consequently, the most violent cartoons are the ones that young people find funniest (McCauley et al., 1983). According to Bandura (1994), comedic cartoons lead to greater imitation of violent behavior than non-comedic cartoons, as comedy acts as a reinforcer. Gutman and Priest (1969) were the first to attempt to empirically determine why violence is funny. The authors were able to test two hypotheses on this matter. First, acts of aggression are viewed as less violent and more amusing when the aggressor is perceived as a good person. On the other hand, if the victim is perceived as deserving the aggression, it will be funnier. Both hypotheses revolve around the legitimization of violent acts, as proposed by Fernández Villanueva et al. (2006).

Major theories of humor seek to explain why violence is so funny. According to the contempt/superiority theory (Gruner, 1978, 1997), violence is funny because it serves as a clear example of superiority over the victim, as the viewer identifies with the aggressor. Theories of incongruity (Shultz, 1972; Suls, 1972) argue that humor arises from incongruent events or elements that have an unexpected resolution. Thus, violence would be another way of highlighting the incongruent situation (Goldstein et al., 1972). Inversion theories (Apter, 1982, 2001; Wyer and Collins, 1992) postulate that humor is only experienced when the person is in a playful mental state (parathetic in Apter’s terms), which provides a “safe space” that allows one to enjoy the activities themselves, without worrying about “serious” future goals. In the parathetic state, violent acts would not be processed as such, since attention would be fixed on the comedy.

All reviewers (Blumberg et al., 2008; Kirsh, 2006; Peters and Blumberg, 2002) are cautious about drawing firm conclusions and agree on the need for further research into the influence of violent animation—whether comedic or not—on children’s behavior. Peters and Blumberg (2002) highlight the importance of analyzing how violence influences the resolution of interpersonal conflicts in cartoons and what message it conveys to children.

Interpersonal conflict is a highly complex everyday psychosocial phenomenon, and the analysis of its representation in the media, such as animated films, is of great importance, as these media have a broad influence on children’s socialization processes. Cinema has evolved over the years, following the dominant paradigm

of each era, which is why the portrayal of conflicts may also have changed, with a consequent impact on socialization processes. For a proper analysis of interpersonal conflict in cinematic narratives, it is important to consider the factors that influence the origin and development of conflicts. In this study, as described above, we will focus on hierarchy and the power relations it entails; the portrayal of gender roles, since stereotypical representations can lead to erroneous beliefs and expectations among viewers regarding the ability of one gender or the other to manage conflicts; and the use of violence, which is frequently employed to develop relationships between characters.

Certain classical theories, such as Rahim and Bonoma's two-dimensional model, are useful for analyzing conflicts. It is also important to consider the possibility that intergroup phenomena may appear in film narratives, since characters often represent a broader group. Furthermore, an understanding of plot and cinematic elements allows for an analysis of conflicts from the perspective of their creators. Stories follow classic patterns, but these must be modified and adapted to the era in which they are set. Conflicts are fundamental to storytelling in film, and they must be portrayed as realistically as possible and in a way that closely mirrors the reality of the time, allowing the viewer to connect with and be drawn to the film and its characters.

2.3. Objectives

The central objective of this study is to analyze how the portrayal of interpersonal conflict in children's animated films has evolved from classic Disney films (1937–1967) to more contemporary films from major animation studios (1990–present). To this end, the following specific objectives have been established:

1. To analyze the shift in the reasons underlying the emergence of interpersonal conflicts.
2. To analyze whether the hierarchical structure in animated films has changed from one era to another and how it influences conflict resolution strategies.
3. To analyze how the representation of gender roles across different eras influences characters' conflict management, with a focus on the portrayal of female protagonists.
4. To analyze the characters' use of violence to resolve conflicts and whether it has changed from one era to another, observing the role of humor in violent acts.

Given the nature of this analysis, attention will be paid to other factors that, although not previously included in the objectives, influence the development of interpersonal conflicts in animated films.

3. Methodology

A study was conducted following the principles of qualitative methodology, with the focus of analysis being various animated feature films from two time periods separated by 20 years. An analysis of the filmic content was performed, focusing primarily on the subplots developed, analyzing the behavior of each character involved and their relationship with the others.

3.1. Sample

The sample consists of 30 animated films (Appendix 1) divided into two groups. The first group comprises titles released up to 1970 (classic cinema), while the second group covers feature films released from 1990 onward (postmodern/contemporary cinema)¹. The selected films belong to major international production companies based in the United States, to which a small sample of Spanish films was added. The size of each group is proportional to the volume of film production, so the first group comprises one-fifth of the sample (six films) and the second group comprises the rest (24 films).

3.2. Methods

The Internet Movie Database (IMDb) was used to search for and select films. The films were viewed via *streaming* platforms (*Netflix*, *Prime Video*, and *Disney+*).

To analyze the films, a template was designed to record the relevant sequences from each film, grouped according to each subplot/conflict within the film (Appendix 2). The template records, sequence by sequence, the time frame in which it occurs, a description of the sequence, the characters involved, their power dynamics, and their conflict management strategy. There is also a section for free notes. The template allows for a general review of the film and quick access to a specific sequence if deemed necessary. A spreadsheet was used to record the co-occurrences related to the analysis.

3.3. Procedure

In selecting the sample frame, the titles from the two most influential animation studios in the world were taken into account: *Walt Disney Pictures* and *DreamWorks Animation*. Within *Walt Disney Pictures*, the two most important animation studios were selected: *Walt Disney Animation Studios* and *Pixar Animation Studios*. To gain insight into Spanish animated cinema, the five Spanish animated films with the highest international box office revenue were also added to the sample (Diboos. Federación de Animación, 2018).

Two groups were formed based on the year of release, with a 20-year gap between them. The student uprisings of May 1968 and the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989 were used as dividing points. This period marks the transition from what might be called “classical” thinking to postmodern thought, with its corresponding impact on the film industry and art.

From 109 eligible films, the 30 that make up the sample were selected. The selection criteria were, first, the film’s impact on society and, second, the number of conflicts present in the film and how they are addressed. Thus, a screening process was conducted to exclude films that did not have a significant impact upon their release or were not relevant to the study because they did not feature conflicts with a major impact on the plot. For this screening process, the synopses of all the films were reviewed, and the films whose synopses did not clarify the importance of the conflicts in the plot were viewed.

First, an open viewing of several films was conducted to narrow down the elements to be included in the analysis template. An initial template model was designed

¹ Contemporary cinema is referred to as postmodern because it was produced under this paradigm, although on several occasions it more closely resembles a type of post-traditional cinema.

which was revised and modified to optimize it for feature-length films. That document included elements that were initially intended to be analyzed but were ultimately excluded because they did not yield conclusive results. For the analysis of the films, an initial exploratory viewing was conducted, during which ideas that could serve as a guide for the analysis itself were freely noted down. After a 24-hour period, the films were viewed again, and the analysis template was completed. Although the template had a fixed structure, it included a section for free notes, which allowed for the recording of emerging ideas that yielded relevant results. All analyses were conducted by the author of this text.

3.4. Data Analysis

A film content analysis was conducted by adapting the methodology proposed by Casetti and Di Chio (1990/2007) to a psychosocial perspective. First, the film was segmented into sequences (codes). The sequencing did not follow strictly cinematic criteria but was adapted to the information relevant to the analysis. The sequences were stratified as the sequencing was carried out. The strata correspond to the film's conflicts, which generally align with the subplots. The sequences were ordered while watching the film, and the strata were ordered based on the relevance of each conflict to the film's plot. Themes were extracted through the strata, corresponding to the specific objectives set forth as well as emerging ideas. Emphasis is placed on the relationship between the protagonists and between the protagonists and the antagonists. The protagonist's general mode of interaction with the surrounding world was also analyzed, as this influences and is influenced by conflicts with the other characters.

4. Results

The structure of the results follows the logic of the specific objectives; however, a general introduction to the most notable findings is provided first. First, the reasons underlying the emergence of conflicts in both eras are discussed, with a comparison between the two. Second, the shift in the hierarchical structure from one era to the next is examined. The influence of this structure on the behavior of the protagonist and antagonist throughout the story is analyzed, using Rahim and Bonoma's (1979) two-dimensional model as a reference. Third, the change in the portrayal of women's roles and how it influences their conflict-resolution strategies is analyzed. Fourth, the changes in the presence of violence in the characters' conflict management are addressed, highlighting the humorous factor as an element that makes violent acts more striking. Finally, a cinematic element that has a major impact on the treatment of conflicts and was not initially considered is discussed: the journey. The types of journeys and how they influence the development of conflict situations are explored.

Conflict is present to a greater or lesser extent in all the animated films reviewed. This element is often central to the stories, driving the plot toward a climax that typically resolves the main conflict. In the vast majority of titles, the main conflict revolves around the hero-villain dynamic. Unlike in the real world, the portrayal of conflict is usually much more simplistic. The hero or protagonist, who is usually a child or teenager, is in the right and has the correct perspective on the conflict, while the villain's intentions are portrayed as malicious and aimed almost exclusively at harming others. This aligns with the view that the hero is a chosen one, called by destiny to embark on an adventure (Campbell, 1949/1959). This view of the

The protagonist without malice and the villain without redemption are hallmarks of classic cinema. During this era, films served an indoctrinating function, punishing behaviors deemed inappropriate for children.

In *Pinocchio* (Luske et al., 1940), the wooden boy is mistreated by the villains for giving in to temptations and disobeying his father. During his final abduction, Pinocchio is taken to an island where children smoke, drink, and play, which irrevocably transforms them into donkeys².

In today's cinema, there is a greater variety of protagonists and antagonists. There are protagonists who use villainous tactics to defeat their enemies, presenting a more positive view of the young hero. There are also anti-hero protagonists—characters with a dark side who ultimately find "the path to goodness." This era also features villains who are forgiven by the protagonist and find redemption, as well as antagonists who are not villains—they confront the protagonist but do not aim to directly destroy them. Children's animated films are a variation of traditional adventure films, which are geared toward adult audiences. As a result, "graphic" scenes are eliminated, and many character relationships are simplified.

In general, significant differences have been found between the cinema of the two eras in the aspects analyzed. The causes of conflict change drastically from one era to the next. The difference lies in how the characters react to the roles assigned to them. In classic cinema, roles and hierarchy are not altered by the protagonist's actions, but rather by a third character, whereas in postmodern cinema, it is the hero who drives the story and strives to increase his power over the antagonist. In both eras, stories with similar premises are presented, where roles establish a very pronounced hierarchy.

In classical cinema, female protagonists behave in a completely passive manner, and the conflict that torments them is resolved through the actions of a powerful prince. In postmodern cinema, these protagonists gradually acquire more power and independence, causing the figure of the savior prince to disappear from some stories, as they themselves embody the typical qualities of this character.

As for the use of violence in conflict resolution, the dynamic has not changed drastically. In both eras, violence is key to the development of relationships between characters and the resolution of conflict. However, in postmodern cinema, there are cases that attempt to condemn violence, even though they continue to resort to it.

Finally, an element of analysis not previously considered has been identified. In contemporary cinema, the journey is frequently used as a narrative device to address the development of various conflicts. Characters in conflict often face a shared journey where they must deal with challenges that transform their relationship, enabling a resolution of the conflict that is satisfactory to both parties.

4.1. Causes of Conflict

The motives that give rise to conflicts in films from both eras are clearly distinct. Classic cinema offers much less variety, with the film's main conflict typically stemming from the villain, who seeks to dominate the protagonist because of who they are. In contemporary cinema, there is a greater variety of motives, notably disobedience, competition, and deception. Disobedience on the part of the protagonist is often a crucial conflict in the plot of the films in which it appears. Conflicts correspond to the level of acceptance

² The example paragraphs were written by the author of the text to illustrate the findings.

of the role and the character's behavior in relation to it. The situation is always linked to the power imbalance between characters, serving as a central element in the initiation, development, and resolution of the conflict.

As previously mentioned, in all the classic films analyzed, the conflict between the main pair (protagonist-villain) arises from an inherent aspect of the protagonist, which is rejected by the villain. The situation is conflictual from the very outset of the story.

Cinderella is a beautiful young woman who is forced to live under the rule of her stepmother and stepsisters after her father's death. Her family hates her because she is her father's biological daughter and because she is more beautiful than they are. They make her their servant and treat her like a slave against her will (*Cinderella*. Geronimi et al., 1950). Bambi is a young fawn who lives happily in the forest, but the humans living nearby hunt him and try to kill him along with the other animals (*Bambi*. Hand et al., 1942).³

On the other hand, the sources of the main conflict in the films of the second period are more varied. There are certain patterns in the way the origins of the stories and conflicts are constructed that would be unthinkable in the films of the first group. As mentioned, one of the most recurring and significant themes is disobedience. It is common for the protagonist, a young idealist, to find himself under the yoke of a superior with more power, whether that superior is a villain or not. The plot begins when the hero disobeys that superior's orders and escapes his power, setting off on his adventure.

In **Tangled** (Greno and Howard, 2010), Rapunzel is a young woman with magical, healing hair who lives confined in a tower under the orders of her false mother, Gothel. Although Gothel had strictly forbidden Rapunzel from leaving the tower, she tricks Gothel and escapes from it. In *Coco* (Unkrich and Molina, 2017), Miguel is the youngest member of a large family where any connection to music is forbidden by family tradition. Miguel wants to be a musician like his idol, which causes his grandmother to punish him frequently. During one of these punishments, Miguel confronts his grandmother and runs away from home to play at a festival, exclaiming, "I don't want to be part of this family" (18:17).⁴

Other recurring motifs that give rise to conflicts of varying importance within the story are competition or rivalry between two characters and lying or deception—whether real or perceived—by one party toward another. Regarding competition, a distinction can be made between that which occurs between the protagonist and the antagonist⁵ and that which arises among protagonists or secondary characters⁶. In the first case, the antagonist resorts to tricks or deceit to achieve their goals. As for lying, it is common for one character to deceive another, and the conflict arises when the other becomes aware of it. Conflicts also frequently arise when one party perceives that the other has betrayed them or has actually done so⁷.

³ The remaining cases are those of Snow White and the Evil Queen (Hand et al., 1937); Pinocchio and "Honest" John (Luske et al., 1940); Arthur and Sir Kay (Reitherman, 1963); and Mowgli and Shere Khan (Reitherman, 1967).

⁴ The other protagonists who initiate the conflict after disobeying are Mulan (Bancroft & Cook, 1998); Moana (Clements et al., 2016); Merida (Andrews et al., 2012); and Justin (Sicilia, 2013).

⁵ This happens with Lightning McQueen and Chick Hicks (Lasseter & Ranft, 2006); and Turbo and Gagné (Soren, 2013).

⁶ This occurs with Lumiere and Din Don (Trousedale & Wise, 1991); the families in *Brave* (Andrews et al., 2012); the *Foosball* players (Campanella, 2013); and Baby and Tim (McGrath, 2017).

⁷ This is the case with Rapunzel and Mother Gothel (Greno & Howard, 2010); the *troupe* and Flik (Lasseter & Stanton, 1998); Sara and Tadeo (Gato, 2012); Héctor and Ernesto de la Cruz (Unkrich & Molina, 2017); Cat and Humpty Dumpty (C. Miller, 2011); and Miguel and Tulio (Bergeron & Paul, 2000).

There is a clear difference in the source of conflict between the two groups. In early cinema, the conflict arises from “being,” whereas in later cinema it arises from “doing.” In classic cinema, the conflict stems from the villain or antagonist, whereas in contemporary cinema it can also stem from the protagonist, as is the case with the “rebels.” At this point, the characters should not be understood as people—that is, as “someone” with a unique identity and behaviors—but rather as roles, that is, “types” of characters who exhibit a range of common behaviors (Casetti and Di Chio, 1990/2007). Thus, the conflict in classic cinema arises from a difference in roles. The protagonist fulfills a role that makes him or her irremediably inferior to the antagonist, and this justifies the conflict. In contemporary cinema, the protagonist also plays an inferior role, but the difference in roles does not necessarily generate conflict. Typically, the beginning of the story shows that if each character adheres to what is expected of them, the situation will remain stable (*the unaltered stage*). However, it is common for the plot to begin when the protagonist does not identify with the role assigned to them and rebels.

The conflict shifts from being about the performance of different roles to being about one party—usually the hero—questioning and refusing to assume that role. The influence of postmodern thought is evident. The protagonists do not believe in what has been established for generations—in the canonical—and they fight to change it. They are nonconformists and rebel against the established power, questioning it from within. This fact is evident in most films of the current era and will have repercussions on the other aspects analyzed in this study.

4.2. Hierarchy and Power

In both periods, there is a clear hierarchy of roles that defines the conflict, as well as how each role behaves toward the other. In classic cinema, this hierarchy remains consistent throughout the film, and the protagonist reacts submissively or avoids the villain’s domineering behavior. In contrast, in contemporary cinema, the hierarchy fluctuates throughout the story, as the protagonist—despite initially adopting an attitude similar to that of his classic counterpart—takes on a more proactive role and seeks to gain the power needed to confront the villain.

Within the hierarchy, it is important to distinguish between power based on status and power based on strength. It is worth noting that, in animated films, power is often defined by having greater strength. In classic cinema, the villain is invariably superior to the protagonist, whether because they have higher status, are more powerful, or a combination of both. The antagonist constantly exhibits behavior aimed at dominating the protagonist, which is usually successful. In other words, they exercise power coercively. The protagonist merely reacts; they are not typically proactive in managing the conflict. This character’s reactions consist of submissive behavior or conflict avoidance.

In *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs*, the wicked queen wants to kill the protagonist, so she flees to the forest and takes refuge in a cottage. The witch pursues her and eventually succeeds in poisoning her through the apple (Hand et al., 1937). In *Pinocchio* (Luske et al., 1940) (p.17), the “honest” John is a scoundrel who seeks only his own gain. Upon meeting Pinocchio, he tries to trick and kidnap him to sell him to the puppeteer Stromboli. Pinocchio is seduced by John’s words and false promises and is ultimately sold.⁸

⁸ Similar behaviors occur between men and animals in *Bambi* (Hand et al., 1942); between the stepmother and stepsisters and Cinderella (Geronimi et al., 1950); and between Sir Kay and Arthur (Reitherman, 1963).

As previously mentioned, the hierarchy remains constant throughout the story. There are no shifts in power between the protagonist and antagonist. The protagonists either fail to rise “above” the antagonists, or they succeed thanks to a more powerful or divine external force.

The witch in *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs* is struck by lightning just as she is about to kill the dwarfs and get away with it (divine intervention), and Snow White is saved by a prince’s kiss (high status) (Hand et al., 1937). On the other hand, Pinocchio escapes his captivity thanks to Jiminy Cricket and the fairy godmother (divine being), but “honest” John and the rest of the villains go unpunished (*Pinocchio*; Luske et al., 1940).⁹

In contemporary cinema, there is also a very distinct hierarchy. The protagonist is usually the lowest-ranking character among the main characters. The villain typically has more power, though not always higher status. This era introduces the non-villainous antagonist, who usually has higher status than the protagonist, and sometimes more power. This role seeks to exercise both legitimate and coercive power. The strategies employed by both types of antagonists at the outset are always ones of domination, and, just as in classic cinema, the protagonists’ reaction is one of submission or avoidance.

Belle is a young dreamer and the daughter of Maurice, an eccentric inventor. Belle is the most attractive woman in town, and Gaston (the antagonist), a boorish seducer, tries to woo her. Belle fends off all of Gaston’s advances, dodging him and cleverly chasing him out of her home. Meanwhile, Belle must go in search of Maurice, who has been kidnapped by the Beast (non-villain antagonist). To save her father, Belle accepts the Beast’s condition that she stay in his castle forever (coercive power) (*Beauty and the Beast*. Trousdale and Wise, 1991). Moana is the daughter of Tui, the chief of a tribe on a small oceanic island (non-villain antagonist). Chief Tui’s rule is that none of the inhabitants may sail beyond the reef surrounding the island, as he considers it very dangerous. When food begins to run short on the island, Moana proposes going fishing beyond the reef, but Tui strictly forbids it, saying: “No one crosses the reef [...] we have a rule [...] it keeps us safe and doesn’t endanger our people” (14:25) (legitimate power). Moana initially accepts her father’s orders, knowing that her people are in danger of starvation (*Moana*. Clements et al., 2016)¹⁰

However, unlike in classical cinema, the protagonist begins to take a proactive role in managing the conflict and is responsible for shifts in power and status. All protagonists in contemporary cinema can fit into Campbell’s (1949/1959) model of the fairy-tale hero, just as those in classical cinema do. They are young and generally marginalized or despised. The difference lies in the fact that the protagonists of postmodern cinema want to be heroes closer to the myth, and to do so, they need power. The call to adventure usually motivates or is motivated by the first conflict. The protagonist flees from his particular oppressor toward an unknown adventure. During his journey, the

⁹ Divine intervention also occurs in **The Sword in the Stone** (Reitherman, 1963) and **The Jungle Book** (Reitherman, 1967). The intervention of a character of higher status also occurs in *Cinderella* (Geronimi et al., 1950), while the protagonist’s escape, with no punishment for the villains, occurs in *Bambi* (Hand et al., 1942).

¹⁰ Submission to one of the antagonists also occurs in **Toy Story** (Lasseter, 1995); **Mulan** (Bancroft & Cook, 1998); **A Bug’s Life** (Lasseter & Stanton, 1998); *Tarzan* (Buck & Lima, 1999); *Shrek* (Adamson & Jenson, 2001); *Tangled* (Greno & Howard, 2010); *Brave* (Andrews et al., 2012); *Socccercastle* (Campanella, 2013); *Justin and the Sword of Courage* (Sicilia, 2013); *Zootopia* (Howard et al., 2016); and *Coco* (Unkrich & Molina, 2017). Avoidance occurs in *The Emperor’s New Groove* (Dindal, 2000); *The Road to El Dorado* (Bergeron & Paul, 2000); *Cars* (Lasseter & Ranft, 2006); and *Planet 51* (Blanco et al., 2009).

“supernatural aid” that grants the power needed to face the future. This aid makes it possible to obtain the specific “golden fleece” that will grant ultimate power, but sometimes the aid itself acts as the fleece, allowing the protagonist to return and confront his oppressor. The protagonist acquires the power necessary to employ a strategy of domination over the other party.

For example, in the story of **Brave** (Andrews et al., 2012), Elinor (a non-villainous antagonist) is a possessive and controlling mother who forces her daughter, Merida, to learn royal manners, even though Merida would rather ride through the forest and shoot her bow. The tension builds until Elinor announces to Merida that she must marry a suitor. The simmering conflict comes to a head, and Merida responds to Elinor: “No, that’s what you’ve been preparing me for my whole life—I won’t settle for that, you can’t force me” (12:36). Later, Merida defies her mother, embarrassing her in front of other royal families. Elinor, furious, throws her daughter’s bow into the fire, and Merida reacts by fleeing the castle on horseback. During her escape, will-o’-the-wisps appear and guide her to a witch’s hut (supernatural aid). The witch gives Merida a cupcake, promising to change her mother. Thus, Merida returns to the castle and tricks her mother into eating the treat (strategy of domination).

This is where the journey would end in Campbell’s formulation of the myth, but postmodern cinema adds further complexity to the equation by introducing the figure of the non-villainous antagonist. Typically, the final outcome involving the villain follows a classic pattern. The villain is defeated and dies or loses all power, though sometimes he repents and is forgiven. The conflict, which began with a win-lose dynamic from the protagonist’s perspective, undergoes a reversal of power (after some fluctuations) and ends in a win-lose scenario. But the conflict with the non-villainous antagonist cannot end with the protagonist’s victory and the antagonist’s defeat. This figure is usually a character for whom the protagonist feels affection, and therefore does not want to replicate their domineering behaviors to subdue them. The protagonist tries to find a way for both to win or, at least, to reach a compromise with one another. This situation is achieved when the power between the two characters is balanced and they are able to see the conflict from the other’s perspective.

Returning to the example *from *Brave** (Andrews et al., 2012) (p. 21), Elinor turns into a bear after eating the cupcake Merida gave her, and the two of them have to flee the castle for fear that Elinor will be killed. During their journey through the countryside, Elinor learns that her palace manners are useless and that Merida is very skilled and happy when it comes to survival tasks. Merida tries to teach her mother how to navigate the forest with good manners, unlike how she behaved in the castle. The reversal of power and roles between the characters in this new situation allows their relationship to improve, as each gains the other’s perspective and vice versa.

In all children’s animated films, a situation with a very clear hierarchy is presented, in which the antagonist (whether a villain or not) has far greater power or status than the protagonist. This power imbalance leads the more powerful figure to exercise coercive power through domineering behavior, while the less powerful figure reacts with submissive or avoidant behavior. In classic cinema, the hierarchy remains stable throughout the plot, and the protagonist ends up fleeing or being “overpowered” in the conflict by a third character more powerful than the villain or through divine intervention. The protagonist never gains enough autonomy to successfully resolve the conflict without help. In contemporary cinema, the protagonist receives the “call to adventure” and escapes the antagonist who controls them. Thanks to “supernatural aid,” they gain more power to confront the antagonist.

In the case of the villainous antagonist, the protagonist's acquisition of power allows them to dominate the antagonist, whereas with the non-villainous antagonist, power must be balanced in order to adopt problem-solving or compromise behaviors. In contemporary stories, the power differential fluctuates throughout the film, whereas in classic cinema this differential is reversed in the story's final climax, thanks to a force or agent external to the protagonist.

4.3. Gender Roles

The female protagonists of classical and postmodern cinema differ drastically. The princesses of early cinema, like the rest of the female protagonists, are completely passive in their stories and in the resolution of conflicts. The difference from their male counterparts is that the men bring the story to a close by taking some proactive action, while the women never take such action. On the other hand, female protagonists in contemporary cinema resemble their male counterparts. It is evident that, since 1990, women have gradually gained more power with each passing film, becoming powerful "princesses" who are fully proactive in managing their conflicts. Today, there are hardly any differences in the behavior of male and female protagonists when it comes to conflict resolution.

Of the films analyzed in the first period, there are two titles whose protagonists are women: *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs* (Hand et al., 1937) and *Cinderella* (Geronimi et al., 1950). The main conflict in both films involves the women being subjected to another woman of greater power and status (the Evil Queen and the Stepmother). Their strategy in the face of this conflict is reactive throughout the story (Snow White flees from the evil queen, and Cinderella submits to her stepmother's tyrannical orders). At the end of the plot, they are rescued by a prince, who resolves the conflict between the women. The male protagonists of this era are also very weak and reactive in the conflict, but the difference lies in the story's conclusion. They exhibit some proactive behavior, whereas the women do not (e.g., Bambi confronts another male toward the end of the film to protect his beloved female (Hand et al., 1942)).

On the other hand, the female protagonists in contemporary cinema are quite different, although the change has not been radical. From *Bella* (Trousdale and Wise, 1991) to *Judy* (Howard et al., 2016)¹¹, female protagonists have gradually gained more and more power within their stories. The beginning of these stories is similar to that of classic cinema: a woman under the control of a superior power, to which she either submits or tries to flee. However, the female protagonist of this era rebels at a certain point. From this event, which sets the plot in motion, the protagonists are proactive in managing their conflicts. They abandon their initial behaviors of submission or avoidance to adopt problem-solving and assertive behaviors.

In fact, the protagonists' general strategy toward their conflicts follows the same pattern, with the notable exceptions of *Beauty and the Beast* and *Brave*, which present variations. First, the protagonist is introduced as a dreamer, with great aspirations and potential, but who is under the yoke of a character with greater power. At the beginning, the protagonist exhibits submissive or avoidant behaviors, but because she disagrees with the imposed power, she rebels and flees from it. From that moment on, her general strategy in the face of any conflict will be one of domination, to overcome all obstacles she encounters in accordance with her interests. However, there comes a point where the protagonist suffers a "defeat" that leaves her emotionally devastated. Subsequently, she experiences a revelation that causes her to return to the strategy of domination, which will be definitive.

¹¹ Including *Mulan* (Bancroft & Cook, 1998); *Rapunzel* (Greno & Howard, 2010); *Merida* (Andrews et al., 2012); and *Moana* (Clements et al., 2016).

She confronts what initially defeated her, this time emerging victorious and becoming a heroine.

Following the example of *Mulan* (Bancroft and Cook, 1998), the film introduces Fa Mulan, a young woman from a village in the Chinese Empire with great aspirations. The story begins with the matchmaker's test, which determines whether a woman has the qualities to be a good wife (control exerted by Chinese village culture). Mulan fails the test disastrously and sets the matchmaker on fire, who exclaims: "You are a disgrace! You may look like a bride, but you will never bring honor to your family!" (10:47). When her father is called to go to war, she snatches his armor and reports to the military camp in his place, even though it is forbidden for women (rebellion). From that moment on, Mulan gains confidence and strength and earns the respect of her fellow soldiers and her captain by posing as a man (strategy of domination). When they face Shan Yu, the villain, Mulan is wounded, which reveals her as a woman. The captain spares her life but expels her from the squadron (defeat). As she returns to her village, Mulan sees that Shan Yu is alive and heading for the empire's capital (revelation). From that moment on, she takes charge and convinces her comrades and the captain to follow her orders to defeat Shan Yu (definitive domination strategy). Her comrades cross-dress to defeat the villain's henchmen, and she manages to defeat Shan Yu thanks to her ingenuity (victory).

The female protagonists in today's cinema are heroines who straddle the line between fairy tales and Campbell's myth, just like their male counterparts. The pattern described above is also common in films where the hero is male, although in those cases there is a greater variety of patterns. Gender differences in conflict resolution in children's animated films have gradually faded, resulting in heroines who are just as powerful as the heroes. Proactively addressing conflicts is no longer the exclusive domain of men, as was the case in classic cinema. In today's films, women employ the full range of conflict management strategies, asserting themselves and achieving their goals proactively.

4.4. Use of violence

Violence plays a significant role in the conflicts depicted in animated films from both eras. Acts of violence serve as strategies of domination that are often effective. At the beginning of the film, the villain uses them to subdue the protagonist, whereas at the end of the story (in contemporary cinema only), it is the protagonist who resorts to them to defeat the villain. Another difference between the two eras is that in postmodern cinema, there are films that condemn violence, yet also resort to it to resolve conflicts.

The protagonist always embodies good and what is right, while the villain embodies evil. In classic cinema, this distinction is very clear from the very beginning of the story: the villain harms the hero because he is evil. The idea that evil could triumph over good is unacceptable, and so the story must unfold toward the triumph of good. In classic cinema, this happens with little intervention from "the good guy." It conveys the idea that good will triumph on its own sooner or later. In contemporary cinema, good and evil are also quite distinct (though evil is sometimes disguised in seemingly good characters), but in this era, it is the protagonist who must assert their position. To do so, on several occasions, the protagonist must use the villain's own "weapons" to defeat them.

As previously mentioned, antagonists exert their power over the protagonist through domineering behavior, which most often translates into violence. Cinema always condemns the antagonist's violence, since the villain is the one who must be rejected. In fact, the villain's aggression is often used to make the viewer feel repulsion toward him. In postmodern cinema, as the story progresses, the protagonist gains enough power to confront the antagonist. With regard to the non-villainous antagonist in contemporary cinema, the protagonist does not resort to violence to resolve the conflict, as this would not lead to a win-win situation. The rapprochement between the protagonist and the non-villainous antagonist is usually peaceful.

In the story of **Brave** (p. 21, 21) (Andrews et al., 2012), Merida gently teaches her mother how to navigate the forest, and they work together to help Elinor regain her human form and resolve the conflict in a way that is satisfactory to both of them. In *Tarzan* (Buck and Lima, 1999), the non-villainous antagonist is Kerchak, the gorilla leader of the troop that took Tarzan in as a baby. Kerchak hates Tarzan for his wayward behavior, but Tarzan resolves the conflict by earning Kerchak's respect when he saves his life.

However, the approach to the villain is completely different. The protagonist acquires enough power to confront the villain and manages to defeat him. But to achieve victory, the protagonist frequently resorts to violence. He uses the villain's own weapons to subdue him, presenting these as acceptable since justice is served. At the end of many stories, the fundamental difference between hero and villain is that the former's violence is acceptable; cinema legitimizes it. In the end, the end justifies the means.

In the story of *Mulan* (p. 23) (Bancroft and Cook, 1998), Mulan sets a trap for Shan Yu and throws him into a hut where a large amount of fireworks are set off, killing the villain. In *Up* (Docter and Peterson, 2009), Carl, the protagonist, causes the villain to fall from a blimp in mid-flight. In *Coco* (p.18) (Unkrich and Molina, 2017), Ernesto de la Cruz, the villain, after being discredited, is grabbed by a hawk and thrown onto a stage where a bell falls on top of him. This is a sign of humiliation, since his death in the world of the living occurred when a bell fell on him in the same way.

A special case is that of the antiheroes of postmodern cinema, whose attitude toward violence is often ambiguous. Depending on the character and the moment in the story, their violent acts are either legitimized or condemned.

Shrek is an ogre whose home has been invaded by other creatures on government orders. He is a violent character, and when he is aggressive toward Donkey, the co-star, the ogre is portrayed as a character with a touch of malice. However, when this character strikes and defeats other characters, such as a group of knights, the violence is portrayed as justifiable (*Shrek*. Adamson and Jenson, 2001).

There are some films from the postmodern period where the villain is not defeated violently. In several of these films, one of the messages they seek to convey is the condemnation of violence¹², so they cannot use it directly against the villain. However, it is evident that violence on the part of characters on the "good" side appears to a greater or lesser extent in all films. One of the main reasons for this is comedy. Children's animated films belong to the comedy genre; they aim to make people laugh, and violence is very comical. In many films, the funniest scenes are those where a character, usually from the "good side," attacks another.

¹² *The Road to El Dorado* (Bergeron & Paul, 2000), *Planet 51* (Blanco et al., 2009), and *Zootopia* (Howard et al., 2016).

Planet 51 (Blanco et al., 2009) seeks to convey a pacifist message against militarization. However, there is a character, Rover, who is a robot mascot and stars in two of the film's funniest scenes. In the first, he is scanning the ground for signs of life and becomes fascinated by a rock. At that moment, a lizard appears and gets in the way between Rover and the rock. Rover tries to shoo the lizard away, but it keeps coming back until the robot crushes it. In the second scene, the military discovers Rover in a restaurant. The robot tries to escape from the soldiers by throwing plates at them and humiliating them in various ways until he achieves his goal.

Another recurring source of "comic" violence is the conflict between the adventure's protagonists. It is common for the protagonists to clash with one another during the journey before a peaceful reconciliation takes place. These confrontations are characterized by their aggressiveness.

In *Tangled* (Greno and Howard, 2010) (p. 18), Flynn (the antihero protagonist) enters Rapunzel's tower, and she knocks him out with a frying pan and ties him to a chair. When Flynn wakes up, Rapunzel hits him again with the frying pan. At the end of the film, the frying pan is adopted as the kingdom's official weapon. In *The Road to El Dorado* (Bergeron and Paul, 2000), Miguel and Tulio, the protagonists, argue and fight on several occasions, though it is worth noting that they always end up forgiving each other.

Violence is an element that appears to some extent in all the films analyzed. Depending on who uses it, it is condemned to a greater or lesser degree, but it tends to be effective when the protagonist uses it. Although there are films that try to show that violence is inappropriate, they resort to it as a comedic device, creating the film's most striking and humorous scenes.

4.5. The journey as a device for conflict

During the course of the analysis, it became apparent that in the portrayal of conflict in postmodern cinema, the journey is frequently used as a cinematic device to develop subplots. This element, not considered in the study's original framework, plays a significant role in the development of interpersonal conflicts and in how the characters involved manage them. The origin of the journey is always linked to the conflict, and it creates a situation of interaction between the characters that allows for the transformation of their relationship and, consequently, the transformation of the conflict.

As described above, in classical cinema the characters are highly polarized from the outset; there is a "good side" and a "bad side." In contrast to this simplistic view, postmodern cinema introduces the figure of the antihero, a protagonist whose intentions and behaviors at the beginning of the film would not fit into the immaculate "good side." The film's plot emphasizes this character's arc of transformation, and to do so, it often makes recurring use of the journey, a cinematic device of great psychosocial interest.

The journey is a shared adventure involving two or a few more characters who are usually in conflict (at least two of them). The journey is always forced upon at least one of the participants and presents a series of challenges—some minor, some major—that the characters must resolve cooperatively, as well as opportunities for them to converse with one another. These elements facilitate the resolution of the conflict and the transformation of the antihero, if there is one.

Judy is a police rabbit who has just joined the force and is trying to earn the respect of her fellow officers. To do so, she sets out to solve a difficult case, but she needs the help of Nick, a con artist fox (antihero). Judy, who has already been swindled

by Nick, blackmails the fox into helping her with her search. At that moment, the two embark on a journey through the challenging city that will gradually bring them closer together and improve their relationship (*Zootopia*. Howard et al., 2016). Kuzko is an arrogant Inca emperor who plans to destroy Pacha's village to build himself a summer palace. Kuzko is turned into a llama by Yzma, the villain, and ends up at Pacha's house. Pacha agrees to guide Kuzko back to the palace when he promises to change his ways (though he is deceiving him). Both face a series of challenges as they try to reach the palace and evade Yzma (*The Emperor and His Crazy Schemes*. Dindal, 2000)¹³.

The reasons behind the journey are varied, but they can generally be grouped into three main types. First are those journeys that are *driven by the conflict* itself. In this case, the consequences of a conflict lead to a journey that is typically forced upon both characters involved. The second type is one in which *the journey generates the conflict*. One of the characters involved "forces" the other to embark on the journey, which creates the conflict. Finally, there is the journey that arises as *a result of an agreement* to resolve a conflict, whether between the characters involved or with a third party. In this last type of journey, this agreement may arise after one of the characters exercises their power in the "for a reward" scenario. In this way, one of the characters agrees to undertake the journey in exchange for obtaining a valuable resource possessed by the other party.

Woody was Andy's favorite toy until Buzz Lightyear showed up. Woody's jealousy leads him to try to shove Buzz behind a dresser so Andy won't find him, but the plan goes awry and Buzz falls out the window. Mr. Potato Head, another toy, thinks Woody's plan was to get rid of Buzz altogether, which causes Woody to jump out the window as well to rescue Buzz. At that moment, the journey begins that will ultimately resolve the conflict between the two toys (a journey sparked by a conflict¹⁴) (*Toy Story*. Lasseter, 1995).

In the story of *Moana* (p. 20), Moana finally defies her father and sets sail for the open sea. The young girl goes in search of Maui, who holds the key to ending the famine plaguing Moana's tribe. To do so, Moana must convince Maui to return a stone he stole from Te Fiti. When Moana finds Maui, she tries to force him to return the stone, but Maui refuses. In the end, he is compelled to accompany Moana thanks to magical assistance, which sparks conflict between the two (a journey that sparks conflict¹⁵) (Clements et al., 2016).

Tim is an only child until Baby arrives in the family—a strange newborn who wears a suit and acts like a businessman. Baby monopolizes all of his parents' attention, which makes Tim very jealous (valuable resource). Finally, Tim discovers that Baby came into the world to find out what PuppyCo, a pet company, is plotting to replace the love for babies. To uncover PuppyCo's plan, the two strike a deal. Tim tells Baby: "I'll help you, just to get rid of you.

Deal?" (37:03). Thus, they embark on a journey that will resolve the conflict

¹³ The antihero's journey also appears in **Toy Story** (Lasseter, 1995); **Planet 51** (Blanco et al., 2009); **Shrek** (Adamson & Jenson, 2001); **Tangled** (Greno & Howard, 2010); *Puss in Boots* (C. Miller, 2011); *Moana* (Clements et al., 2016); and *The Boss Baby* (McGrath, 2017). The journey without an antihero occurs in *Up* (Docter & Peterson, 2009); *Brave* (Andrews et al., 2012); *Turbo* (Soren, 2013); and *Capture the Flag* (Gato, 2015).

¹⁴ This type of journey motif also appears in *Brave* (Andrews et al., 2012); *Turbo* (Soren, 2013); and *Zootopia* (Howard et al., 2016).

¹⁵ This type of origin of the journey also appears in *Planet 51* (Blanco et al., 2009); and *Capture the Flag* (Gato, 2015).

between the two, but which ultimately transforms it (a journey that occurs following an agreement between the conflicting parties¹⁶) (*The Boss Baby*. McGrath, 2017).

Over the course of the journey, the conflict evolves based on how the relationship between the characters develops, and this relationship is shaped by what happens during the journey. It is common for challenges to arise during the adventure that the characters must overcome together, and for the success of the task to depend on their cooperation. A variation of this challenge is one that one of the characters faces alone, but ultimately overcomes thanks to the help of the other traveler.

For example, in *Moana* (pp. 20, 26), Moana and Maui must face a giant crab to retrieve Maui's lost weapon. Maui devises a plan in which they cooperate to trick the crab and steal the weapon (Clements et al., 2016). In *Puss in Boots*, the characters must flee from a giant goose, but one of them has to be rescued and saved by the other (Miller, 2011).

Furthermore, the journey allows the characters to engage in dialogue, which helps the conflict develop, although their positions do not always converge from the outset. The characters in conflict usually belong to different groups (e.g., a rabbit and a fox, a human and an *alien*, an old man and a child, an emperor and a villager), which establishes two completely distinct roles that justify the incompatibility of their positions. However, the journey is an ideal situation for each to express their points of view and find common ground. The characters change their stance on the conflict—and especially their stance toward the other party—in ways that range from subtle to drastic.

In **Planet 51** (Blanco et al., 2009) (p. 25), Chuck is a cocky astronaut who lands on an alien planet. There he meets Lem, a young *alien* dealing with the classic problems of a teenager. Chuck asks Lem for help in retrieving his space module, which puts the *alien* in danger. The journey to retrieve the module sparks conflict between the two, but little by little they realize they aren't so different. Lem faces the same struggles Chuck did in his youth, and Chuck isn't the dangerous alien the press makes him out to be. In the story of *Zootopia* (p.25), Judy discovers that Nick, despite being a con artist, has a good heart. She discovers that Nick was humiliated as a child for being a "predator" who wanted to play with "prey," just as Judy was also humiliated for being a small "prey" who wanted to pursue a career among big "predators." Nick also discovers that Judy, despite being a police officer, has a strong sense of justice and does not irrationally hate "predators" (Howard et al., 2016).

The journey is key to resolving the conflict between the characters involved. The conflict doesn't necessarily have to be fully resolved during the journey; the journey may end with the characters still at odds, but without it, the eventual resolution could not take place. It is common for the relationship between characters to experience ups and downs during the journey, and there may even be a breakdown that brings the journey to an end or at least temporarily halts it. However, the events that occur during the journey allow the characters to reconsider their positions and lead to a definitive reconciliation between them, achieving a resolution of the conflict that is satisfactory to both parties.

Returning to the story of *Zootopia* (pp. 25, 27), Judy and Nick's journey is marked by Nick's attempts at sabotage and Judy's underhanded tactics, but they overcome challenges and discuss their past, which initially resolves their first conflict.

¹⁶ This type of journey motif also appears in *The Emperor's New Groove* (Dindal, 2000); *Shrek* (Adamson & Jenson, 2001); *Tangled* (Grenou & Howard, 2010); and *Puss in Boots* (C. Miller, 2011).

However, Judy offends Nick because of the press, and he leaves her. Later, when Judy realizes the real problem, she goes back to Nick, who forgives her, playfully using the same underhanded trick she had used on him during the trip (Howard et al., 2016). In *The Emperor's New Groove* (p. 26), Pacha and Kuzko's journey is marked by the former's solidarity and the latter's arrogance. When they reach a rickety bridge, Pacha falls, left hanging from some vines. At that moment, Kuzko, who is already near the palace, takes the opportunity to mock Pacha and expose the lie, but he also falls and is left hanging from the vines. The two fight, and the bridge finally breaks, leaving them both trapped at the bottom of a narrow gorge where there are crocodiles. The characters are forced to cooperate to climb up, and once at the top, Kuzko saves Pacha's life. It seems the conflict has been resolved, but because of a misunderstanding, Kuzko breaks up with Pacha and accuses him of being a liar: "You don't want to take me to the palace; you want me to stay with these hooves forever! [...] You're only interested in your... your ridiculous mountain; you don't care about me, so get lost, go away!" (49:52). Later, realizing that Pacha was right, he returns to him, and Pacha graciously forgives him (Dindal, 2000).¹⁷

As we have seen, the journey creates an ideal setting for resolving the conflict between the parties involved, thanks to cooperative challenges and the opportunity to exchange perspectives. Furthermore, in the case of journeys featuring antiheroes, these characters undergo a transformation. In their case, not only is the conflict in question resolved, but the character's attitude changes drastically through contact with the other traveler. The con artist becomes a police officer, and the arrogant emperor becomes a friend of the people. The antihero's transformation can be seen as the transmission of the companion's good qualities to the antihero. The conflict in this case is only resolved when that transmission begins to take place, never before.

5. Discussion

Children's animated films are particularly significant because of their target audience and the amount of time that audience spends watching them. The portrayal of many aspects on the big screen has changed drastically, following the prevailing trends of each era. One such aspect is interpersonal conflict, which serves as the "driving force" behind many subplots and whose portrayal is a consequence of other elements whose changes are more explicit, such as hierarchy, the use of violence, or gender stereotypes. Changes in society have led, first and foremost, to a drastic shift in the approach to storytelling and, consequently, in screenplays. Almost all the films analyzed feature children, adolescents, or young adults as protagonists. This makes it easier for the target audience to identify with the characters, as they are likely to share similar experiences in their own lives (Sánchez-Escalonilla, 2004). The similarity between character and viewer is one of the factors that can have the greatest influence on the replication of behaviors seen on screen (Hapkiewicz, 1979).

5.1. Reasons for the conflict

The difference between the two eras lies in the perspective from which the stories are constructed. Classic cinema, according to Dorfman and Mattelart (1987), is constructed for children based on traditional adult values. As a result, the films are clearly didactic and condemn all behaviors that were considered inappropriate for a child at that time, such that the protagonists must remain passive in managing their conflicts with

¹⁷ Character breakdowns also appear in **Shrek** (Adamson & Jenson, 2001); **Puss in Boots** (C. Miller, 2011); **Turbo** (Soren, 2013); **Moana** (Clements et al., 2016); and **The Boss Baby** (McGrath, 2017).

adults, and women even more so. On the other hand, today's cinema is written to empower young people. The character in this era is called to adventure, whereas the character in classic cinema suffers from a refusal of the call (Campbell, 1949/1959). Thus, the contemporary protagonist must be active, confronting the established power in order to reform it. It is a call to youth to convey that disobedience need not be a bad decision. The premises of many contemporary feature films address conflicts typical of puberty and adolescence: a young, idealistic character, often a teenager, sees their aspirations and dreams thwarted by a hierarchical superior, often a parent. The story revolves around how the protagonist disobeys in order to ultimately assert their vision over that of their father or mother.

Thus, the underlying causes of conflict in these films are a direct consequence of their creators' way of thinking. In the mid-20th century, the dominant school of thought was Parsons' functionalism (1951/1999). The role of children dictated that they should be submissive and obey adults' orders without question. Furthermore, women were expected to conform to standards of beauty, purity, and submissive behavior that were clearer and more pronounced than those for men (e.g., Davis, 2006; Thompson and Zerbinos, 1995). Roles at that time were clearly defined, and everyone accepted what was expected of them, whereas today these roles are questioned rather than accepted. The influence of postmodern thought grants children greater autonomy, viewing them as having the same rights as adults and believing they should oppose adults if they consider their orders unjust. However, it is unclear to what extent these narratives influence adolescents when they rebel against what they consider unfair.

The origin of conflicts in classical cinema can also be understood from a cognitive perspective. In this case, villains exhibit a strong bias toward self-righteousness (Deschamps and Beauvois, 1994/1996), as they attribute their problems and failures to the mere existence of the protagonist, who often serves as a "scapegoat." In this way, they attempt to subdue or persecute him. The *locus* of all attributions in classical cinema is internal and stable, since the roles are never questioned. In postmodern cinema, the protagonist also attributes the behavior of the non-villainous antagonist to internal and stable causes, as a symbol of the functionalism still present in older generations.

5.2. Hierarchy and Power

Regarding the hierarchical structure, in classic animated cinema, the same rigidity detected by Dorfman and Mattelart (1987) in comic strips is repeated. In the cinema of that era, there is only an increase in power and advancement within the hierarchical structure when there is an association with a hierarchical superior, such as a marriage. The protagonists are relegated to fleeing or waiting to be saved, as they will never be able to acquire enough power to confront their enemy. The conflict is always dominated by the antagonist, and the only way for the situation to change is through the action of a more powerful third party. In this era, the conflict is always initiated by the antagonist villain, who is more powerful than the protagonist but does not typically have higher status. This pattern aligns with the findings of Anicich et al. (in press), which indicate that individuals with power but without status are more likely to initiate conflicts and exercise coercive power.

Classic cinema conveys a message that encourages people to fulfill their assigned roles despite adversity. If a person is good and lives up to expectations, they will be saved; however, the underlying hierarchical structure that perpetuates inequalities between roles is not criticized. The fact that villains go unpunished implies that their behavior is not punishable and that their role is also functional within the depicted society. Children and women

should not have power over adults and men, as this would imply a change in the established role structure. Thus, the portrayal of conflict between roles is negative, as it would challenge what has been established for generations.

Contrary to Artz's (2003) analysis, conflict in contemporary cinema is more dynamic, as the hierarchical structure does not remain rigid throughout the narrative. The difference in results may stem from the focus of the analysis. Artz treated the titles as static images, as his goal was to analyze the power of the Disney company, whereas this study considers the film as a story, since the objective is to analyze the progression of the narrative. Continuing with the analysis of conflict, in this era the protagonist is endowed with the ability to acquire power to confront the opposing side in their conflict. In this way, the unjust coercive power constantly employed by the antagonists is challenged. Noteworthy is the differential treatment given to villainous and non-villainous antagonists. In the case of the former, coercive power is replicated, and the protagonists dominate the villain in a manner similar to how the villain dominated them. The latter, however, are characters for whom the protagonist feels affection (such as family members); thus, exercising coercive power over them would be inappropriate, so the protagonist seeks to reach a resolution to the conflict that satisfies both parties. To achieve this, legitimate power (in Raven and French's typology) or traditional authority (in Weber's typology) is challenged.

Stories in animated films are generally set in monarchical or similar societies, where authority is vested in a family whose patriarch (or, at times, matriarch) holds the highest power. Postmodern cinema suggests that established norms should not be blindly replicated and accepted from one generation to the next, and that challenging authority may be appropriate. This reform of traditional authority must come from within, since it is the monarchs' own descendants who challenge it and attempt to shift the ruler's perspective. Returning to the idea of the non-villainous antagonist's behavior as a symbol of modern functionalism, this challenge and subsequent conflict by the young people would represent the struggle and transition of this school of thought toward the logic of postmodernity.

Following Raven and French's (1959) typology, the type of power that appears most frequently in the analysis is coercive power, as it is the most likely to generate conflict. If power remains virtually unchanged (as in classic cinema), the powerful party employs domineering behaviors, while the other party has no choice but to submit. Legitimate power, like traditional authority (Weber, 1922/1993), generates conflict in children's animated films because it must be questioned from a postmodern perspective. The remaining types of power (reward, reference, and expert), like Weber's other types of authority (legal-rational and charismatic), do not typically generate conflict; therefore, they have not appeared in the analysis, with a few exceptions.

The protagonist gains power over the course of the adventure, often thanks to supernatural assistance. Bolick and Nowicki (1984) noted that the reinforcements depicted in animation often reflect an external locus of control, which presumably has a negative impact on young viewers' expectations of reinforcement. Thus, the call to nonconformity mentioned earlier may be undermined by the learning of unrealistic contingency expectations, as the viewer may come to believe that the only way for "rebellion" to be effective is through magical assistance. The film's director may include this element of magical assistance to reinforce the idea of what is considered just, yet difficult to change.

5.3. Gender Roles

Perhaps the aspect of conflict that has been most analyzed and criticized due to societal change is the portrayal of gender roles. The heroines of classic cinema fulfill what was expected of a woman at that time: to be passive, submissive, pure, innocent, and devoted to household chores. This directly impacts their attitude toward conflict, as their primary strategy is submission, even obeying degrading and humiliating orders. The only way the conflict can be resolved in her favor is through a handsome man who decides to take her in and marry her. This portrayal reflects the ideals of the Victorian patriarchal family, which remained one of the most desirable family forms well into the 20th century (for a detailed analysis, see Davis, 2006).

On the other hand, the female protagonists of today's cinema are portrayed from the very beginning of the story as idealists and fighters, capable of battling for their goals and dreams. The film's plot revolves around how this character overcomes—not without effort—all the obstacles that stand in the way of her goal. Those who were once submissive princesses are now dominant queens, with no need for a man to act on their behalf. The conflict-management strategies of female protagonists in contemporary cinema have come to match those of male protagonists. However, this evolution has been gradual, such that in stories from the late 20th and early 21st centuries, the figure of the man with whom the princess falls in love continued to appear. In recent feature films starring women (e.g., *Moana*, *Zootopia*), the male figure has become that of a companion—often a bumbling antihero—who does not necessarily have to be a romantic partner. Nevertheless, complete equality has not yet been achieved, as there are hardly any stories starring women whose plot does not revolve around rebellion. The woman as the heroic protagonist is not yet normalized, as there is very little diversity in behavioral patterns in these films. The gender roles portrayed in postmodern cinema are much more complex than those in classical cinema, responding to the expectations of a society that no longer accepts the inferiority of women (Radovic and Radulovic, 2016).

In the absence of up-to-date experimental studies, the impact of this phenomenon on children's attitudes is presumably positive. In the study by Aubrey and Harrison (2004), girls preferred female characters only when they were counter-stereotypical, whereas boys preferred stereotypical content. These results suggest that girls reject the negative portrayal of the classic female stereotype. According to social learning theory (Bandura, 1969, 1976), boys and girls learn typical gender roles through observation. Changing the portrayal of women in animated films by eliminating stereotypical behaviors may help reduce gender stereotypes regarding how men and women communicate and manage conflict. The current view is more in line with empirical research, which indicates that there is no difference in conflict management between men and women (Hocker and Wilmot, 2018).

5.4. The Use of Violence

Since the 1950s, there has been extensive debate regarding the effect that violence depicted in children's animation has on children. There is still no consensus on whether young viewers replicate the aggressive acts they see on screen. Despite the large amount of research and debate on the subject, the levels of violence in this type of content remain very high, and have even increased in recent years. In the present study, violent acts were found in all of the films analyzed, which is consistent with the findings of other studies (e.g., Fernández Villanueva et al., 2004).

Hapkiewicz (1979) noted that the content of the animation itself could be a determining factor in whether it is replicated. The vast majority of studies use cartoons created *specifically* for the experiment or animation in series format. It is worth noting the difference between animated series and films. The former feature highly stereotyped and exaggerated characters, whose adventures last between 20 and 30 minutes per episode. These are flat characters who repeat the same behavioral pattern in similar situations, and in no case does this behavior have long-term consequences, since a key principle of these series is that the episode ends as it began. On the other hand, films present longer stories (around 90 minutes), where characters undergo a transformation arc. Their behavior is influenced by various subplots and has definitive consequences, since a film can never end as it began (Sánchez-Escalonilla, 2004).

In the films analyzed, violence is used as an effective method for resolving conflicts. Thus, domination is the most recurring strategy, and the one that is usually definitive in defeating the villain. Peters and Blumberg (2002) suggest that children's replication of violence may be situational and not remain stable over time, consistent with the hypothesis that animated violence momentarily increases the viewer's aggressive *arousal* (Mueller and Donnerstein, 1983). These ideas are based on studies using short-form animated films as their subjects, where violence has no consequences because the relationships between characters remain unchanged from episode to episode. However, as mentioned, violence in feature-length films presents a series of contingencies that are typically positive for the protagonist's interests. Following Bandura's social learning theory (1969, 1976), a child is more likely to replicate these behaviors in the face of similar contextual cues, since they have learned that using violence resolves conflict satisfactorily.

It is worth noting the distinction between antagonists introduced by postmodern cinema. Violence is effective against villains, but not against non-villainous antagonists. This latter type of antagonist, who are often relatives of the protagonist, presents a type of conflict that, as mentioned, is common among children and adolescents. Although contemporary cinema encourages disobedience and rebellion if conditions are deemed unjust, it promotes the idea that violence is not the solution for resolving family conflicts. However, one of the keys to resolving these conflicts is "magical help," which presumably generates expectations of an external locus of control (Bolick and Nowicki, 1984). Classic cinema shows that conflicts will be resolved by the action of a third party, without the protagonist being able to do anything, while contemporary cinema calls on the protagonist to act; however, as previously mentioned, their ability to exert power in the conflict is provided by an external and unreal agent.

Another important aspect of the violence depicted in animation is whether it is legitimized or condemned. Good and evil in these feature films are highly polarized and clearly distinguished. The protagonist represents good and the antagonist represents evil, so the viewer does not have to make a great cognitive effort to choose one side or the other or to decide which side is right. In this way, the protagonists' violence is legitimized and the antagonists' is condemned. Fernández Villanueva et al. (2006) indicate that it is not necessary to explicitly explain the meaning of violent acts to legitimize them. To achieve this, it is simply enough to show likable characters who solve problems (the protagonist heroes) and victims who are guilty or deserving of punishment (the antagonist villains), as well as positive consequences following the violent act. The violence perpetrated by the antagonists is condemned in the opposite manner.

In classic cinema, the violence perpetrated by “the good guys” is drastically reduced compared to the fairy tales that inspired it. In the stories of the Brothers Grimm, for example, villains suffer cruel punishments for their actions. In Disney’s film adaptation, these punishments are eliminated, possibly to reinforce the idea of purity and innocence displayed by the protagonists and intended to be instilled in children. In contemporary cinema, protagonists make use of the villains’ “weapons” and inflict violence upon them, but always in a proportionate manner, presenting a situation of justice that facilitates approval of their actions. However, in some contemporary films, certain violent acts committed by antihero protagonists are condemned. This fact adds complexity to the legitimization of violence in postmodern cinema, showing the viewer that the protagonist is not always “good” without exception.

Another striking aspect of violence—and one that facilitates its legitimization—is its comedic nature. In all contemporary films, violence has a strong comedic effect, creating the film’s most memorable scenes. It is noteworthy that the legitimization of violence through humor, far from being a mitigating factor in real life, could be an aggravating factor in the eyes of a judge (Fernández Villanueva et al., 2006). Violence is only comical when it is perpetrated by the “good side” or when the victim is the “bad side.” This relates to classical theories of humor, such as the contempt/superiority theory (Gruner, 1978, 1997). According to this theory, comedy arises from the viewer’s identification with the “good side,” with the violent act serving as a celebration of superiority over the other. Other theories of humor downplay the role of violence as a comic element. Theories of incongruity (Shultz, 1972; Suls, 1972) argue that violence is simply another way of highlighting the unexpected resolution of the incongruous situation (Goldstein et al., 1972). Similarly, inversion theories (Apter, 1982, 2001; Wyer and Collins, 1992) postulate that in the paratheatrical state, in which films are viewed, violence has little impact, since the viewer’s attention is directed toward the comedy.

No empirical studies have been found to test whether violence in a comedic context is imitated more than in a non-comedic one. According to Bandura’s social learning theory and the theory of superiority, humor would serve to reinforce violent acts, in addition to providing satisfaction by demonstrating superiority over the other party. Presumably, this would lead to greater replication of violent acts as a strategy for resolving conflicts. However, according to the hypothesis of the trivialization of violence advocated by authors such as Kirsh (2006) or Potter and Warren (1998), as well as inversion theories, the comic effect would mask the underlying violent act and have no impact on the viewer’s behavior. In any case, violence is one of the most frequently used devices in animated films, and it is even more prevalent in contemporary cinema than in classic cinema, as it is employed for comic effect. It is incongruous that feature films that condemn the use of violence resort to it to entertain viewers.

5.5. The Journey as a Device for Conflict

During the course of the analysis, a narrative device was identified that is widely used in postmodern cinema and has a significant impact on the development of conflicts in subplots: the journey. What is used in animated films as a device that spans more or less the entire duration of the film originates from a film genre that emerged in the 1960s: *road movies*. This genre emerged from the crisis of classical cinema (García Ochoa, 2018) and breaks with many of the conventions of that tradition. The most important aspect of this genre is the break with what is left behind, embarking on a journey with no fixed destination and no need to reach any specific goal.

Contemporary animated films draw inspiration from this postmodern film genre to develop the relationship between two main characters. The characters always begin their journey in conflict, and the course of their journey is crucial to resolving the confrontation between them. It is very common for the characters to belong to different social groups (e.g., royalty and commoners, or prey and predator) and to disregard the other party's perspective based on stereotypical judgments. Thus, according to Allport's (1954) theory of intergroup contact, three of the four criteria for optimal contact are met. First, equality of status does not typically exist at the beginning of the journey. However, the balance of power between the characters fluctuates throughout the journey, eventually reaching a point where they are equal. Second, the pursuit of common goals is driven by the nature of the journey and the obstacles that arise along the way. These obstacles give rise to the third and final criterion, cooperation, since, to overcome them, the characters must necessarily collaborate.

The presence of these challenges, which the characters must overcome through cooperation, takes on particular significance in films. First, it creates emotionally charged and spectacular moments for the audience; second, it forces the characters to work together to achieve a goal that would be impossible to attain alone. A situation of overarching goals arises, which greatly reduces hostility among the characters (Sherif, 1958, 1966). In the films analyzed, the balance of power often allows for initial steps toward a peaceful and consensual resolution of the conflict, but it is the overarching goals of the challenges and obstacles encountered during the journey that lead to a greater reduction in tension between the parties, as well as behaviors of compromise or integration. Following Pettigrew's (1998) reformulation of intergroup contact, the journey in animated films would facilitate the first phase: decategorization (Brewer and Miller, 1984). The contact situation leads to attention being paid to personalized information about the other party, separating the individual from their social category.

In cases where the antihero appears, the story focuses heavily on this character's arc of transformation. This aspect would be unthinkable in classic cinema, since characters fulfill their assigned roles throughout the story, and a change in a character's psychological nature would call those roles into question. This questioning is precisely what contemporary cinema seeks. It rejects the static nature of classic cinema and advocates for the need for change so that society can progress. The antihero plays a role at the beginning of the story, but interaction with other characters causes the antihero to rethink their behavior through conflict.

5.6. Practical implications

Film is a medium with great educational potential. Since the last century, various authors have highlighted film as a highly useful educational tool (e.g., Carpenter and McLuhan, 1960/1974; de Pablos Pons, 1986; García Amilburu, 2000; Pla and Torrent, 2003; Porter-Moix, 1978; de la Torre et al., 2005). Porter-Moix (1978) distinguished three types of relationships between film and education. First, *teaching film* involves learning about film production. Second, *teaching with film* involves learning about topics depicted in films, such as historical events or conflict itself. Finally, *teaching through film* refers to film as a motivator for learning.

In recent years, the importance of conflict management in schools has been highlighted, leading to the creation of various programs to educate about positive conflict resolution, generally through peer mediation programs (e.g., Lester et al., 2017; Sellman, 2011; Usó et al., 2016). Animated films can serve as a valuable complement to conflict education. This type of film can motivate students in their learning process (teaching through film), and an analysis of the various conflicts presented can

facilitate learning about various conflict-related elements, such as violence or gender roles (teaching through film).

There are some approaches to working with this type of film. Nathanson and Cantor (2000) suggest addressing the violence depicted in animation through adult-guided viewing. In this way, the adult's role is to encourage identification with and empathy toward the victim of the aggression. Another commonly used approach to reduce the impact of violence is for the adult to make negative comments about the violent acts (Cantor and Wilson, 2003; Grusec, 1973; Hicks, 1968). The goal of this technique is to change the young viewer's perception that violence has positive consequences, which is expected to lead to less imitation (Cantor and Wilson, 2003). On the other hand, Sánchez-Labela Martín (2017) proposes watching this type of film to identify and analyze the situations of inequality and gender-based violence present in them.

This study serves as an initial exploration of the analysis of the representation of interpersonal conflict in cinema, specifically in popular children's animated films. The complexity of this psychosocial phenomenon makes it impossible to fully address with a single analysis. However, its potential as a pedagogical complement to formal education is highlighted. The rise of *streaming* platforms has led to increased consumption of all animation formats, allowing children to freely choose what content to watch. Therefore, it is necessary to expand the study of psychosocial phenomena to other formats that are highly popular among children.

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7. Appendices

7.1. Appendix 1. Films included in the sample

Original Title	Title in Spain	Director(s)	Year	Main Animation Studio
Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs	Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs	David Hand, William Cottrell, Wilfred Jackson, Larry Morey, Perce Pearce, and Ben Sharpsteen	1937	Walt Disney Animation Studios
Pinocchio	Pinocchio	Hamilton Luske, Ben Sharpsteen, Norman Ferguson, T. Hee, Wilfred Jackson, Jack Kinney and Bill Roberts	1940	Walt Disney Animation Studios
Bambi	Bambi	David Hand, James Algar, Samuel Armstrong, Graham Heid, and Bill Roberts	1942	Walt Disney Animation Studios
Cinderella	Cinderella	Clyde Geronimi, Wilfred Jackson, and Hamilton Luske	1950	Walt Disney Animation Studios
The Sword in the Stone	The Sword in the Stone	Wolfgang Reitherman	1963	Walt Disney Animation Studios
Jungle Book	The Jungle Book	Wolfgang Reitherman	1967	Walt Disney Animation Studios
Beauty and the Beast	Beauty and the Beast	Gary Trousdale and Kirk Wise	1991	Walt Disney Animation Studios
Toy Story	Toy Story	John Lasseter	1995	Pixar Animation Studios
Mulan	Mulan	Tony Bancroft and Barry Cook	1998	Walt Disney Animation Studios
A Bug's Life	A Bug's Life	John Lasseter and Andrew Stanton	1998	Pixar Animation Studios
Tarzan	Tarzan	Chris Buck and Kevin Lima	1999	Walt Disney Animation Studios
Emperor's New Groove	The Emperor's New Groove	Mark Dindal	2000	Walt Disney Animation Studios
Road to El Dorado	The Road to El Dorado	Bibo Bergeron and Don Paul	2000	DreamWorks Animation
Shrek	Shrek	Andrew Adamson and Vicky Jenson	2001	DreamWorks Animation
Madagascar	Madagascar	Eric Darnell and Tom McGrath	2005	DreamWorks Animation
	Cars	John Lasseter and Joe Ranft	2006	Pixar Animation Studios
51	Planet 51	Jorge Blanco, Javier Abad, and Marcos Martínez	2009	Ilion Animation Studios
	Up	Pete Docter and Bob Peterson	2009	Pixar Animation Studios
Tangled	Tangled	Nathan Greno and Byron Howard	2010	Walt Disney Animation Studios
in Boots	Puss in Boots	Chris Miller	2011	DreamWorks Animation
The Adventures of Tadeo Jones	The Adventures of Tadeo Jones	Enrique Gato	2012	Telecinco Cinema
Brave	Brave	Mark Andrews, Brenda Chapman, and Steve Purcell	2012	Pixar Animation Studios
Table Soccer	Foosball	Juan José Campanella	2013	100 Bares, Atresmedia Cine
Justin and the Sword of Courage	Justin and the Sword of Courage	Manuel Sicilia	2013	Kandor Graphics
Turbo	Turbo	David Soren	2013	DreamWorks Animation

Capture the Flag	Capture the Flag	Enrique Gato	2015	Telecinco Cinema
Moana	Moana	RON CLEMENTS, JOHNNY MUSKER, DOM MONAGHAN, CHRIS WILLIAMS	2016	Walt Disney Animation Studios
Zootopia	Zootopia	Byron Howard, Rich Moore, and Jared Bush	2016	Walt Disney Animation Studios
Coco	Coco	Lee Unkrich and Adrian Molina	2017	Pixar Animation Studios
The Boss Baby	The Boss Baby	Tom McGrath	2017	DreamWorks Animation

7.2. Appendix 2. Analysis Template

Conflict: _____

Movie: _____

Scene : “ ”

Scene : “ ”

Scene : “ ”

Character	Style	Emotion		Character	Style	Emotion		Character	Style	Emotion

Power Mica Diná:

Powerplay:

Power Mina:

Scene description:

Scene description:

Scene description:

Notes:

Notes:

Notes: